

World in Brief: America launches ninth round of strikes; Spain win the World Cup

America launched a barrage of strikes on **Iran**, the ninth in as many days. The attack came shortly after America announced that three of its soldiers had been killed by Iranian strikes. Meanwhile Iran promised not to let a “single drop” of oil pass through the Strait of Hormuz. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, climbed above \$90 a barrel for the first time in more than a month.

Ukraine accused **Russia** of hitting a Turkish cargo ship carrying grain. Russia did not respond to the claim. Earlier the Kremlin carried out a major attack on Kyiv, the **Ukrainian** capital, which officials said killed at least six people. Meanwhile Vladimir Putin thanked North Korea for supporting Russia after meeting the country’s foreign minister in Moscow.

Ryanair, Europe’s largest budget airline, reported lacklustre results for the second quarter of 2026. Post-tax profit was €538m (\$615m), down by a third from the same period last year and below analysts’ expectations. That is partly because the Iran war has increased fuel prices; Ryanair’s operating costs were up by 11% year on year. EasyJet, a rival, reports on Wednesday.

Andy Burnham will become Britain’s prime minister today. Mr Burnham has made clear his disapproval of deregulation, privatisation and deindustrialisation. But he has said little about how he will tackle Britain’s economic problems, including a chronic lack of productivity growth and stagnating living standards. As prime minister, he needs a clear vision and **bold policies**. His choice for chancellor will be closely watched.

Two of China’s “national team”, a group of state-owned asset managers, said that they were buying more **Chinese equities** to

help stabilise the country's capital markets. China has not been immune from last week's tech-stock rout—the CSI 300, an index of the country's biggest stocks, fell by more than 5%. China's securities regulator is reportedly meeting with companies and investors today to discuss how best to counter volatility.

Supporters of **India's Cockroach Janata Party** gathered in Delhi to begin a march on parliament, defying police orders. The CJP began as a satirical social-media account following the leak of exam papers, but has since grown into a protest movement calling for education reform. On Saturday police forcibly moved Sonam Wangchuk, a hunger-striking activist, to a local hospital. But that has only galvanised protesters.

Spain won the **World Cup** for the second time, defeating Argentina 1-0. Though they dominated the final, Spain could only break down the reigning world champions, who had been reduced to ten men, in the second half of extra time. President Donald Trump, one of many world leaders in attendance, handed over the trophy to the victors along with Gianni Infantino, **FIFA's controversial boss**.

Figure of the day: 26%. The share of seats in Parliament that are in the north of England. The region has been rising in political salience—with a **new British prime minister** to show for it.

No off-ramp in the Gulf war



Photograph: EPA

With each passing day, what began as a limited clash between America and Iran looks to be spiralling into something bigger. They have traded strikes for nine consecutive nights. America is bombing bridges and tunnels in southern Iran, particularly around Bandar Abbas, its main port city. Iran has repeatedly attacked power and water infrastructure in Kuwait. At least two [American soldiers were killed](#) by a missile strike in Jordan on Friday.

What comes next is hard to predict. The Pentagon is sending additional refuelling tankers to Israel, a sign that it is weighing further escalation. Mediators are still trying to urge both sides back to negotiations, thus far unsuccessfully. Economic considerations should eventually force them to talk. The [price of oil](#) is already up 23% this month, and an American blockade of Iran's ports will add to the regime's economic woes. The question is how long that takes—and how much damage they will do to the region first.

Instagram on trial over teen addiction



Photograph: Getty Images

On Monday Meta goes on trial in Tennessee, accused of harming young users' mental health with its Instagram platform. The state alleges the social-media giant violated the Tennessee Consumer Protection Act by designing Instagram as an “addiction machine” targeting minors. It says Mark Zuckerberg, Meta’s CEO, repeatedly declined employees’ requests to fund measures to mitigate Instagram’s harmful effects. Meta has argued that it has strong safety measures in place to protect teens. It is also likely to challenge evidence that social media damages youngsters’ mental health.

Recent legal setbacks suggest it faces an uphill battle in the courtroom. In March jurors in California found [Meta and Google guilty](#) of harming young users. The case focused on the [design of their platforms](#) rather than user-generated content. The latter benefits from more legal protection. Meta has appealed. It faces lawsuits over alleged harm to youngsters by more than 40 states, including one in federal court next month in Oakland, California.

Weapons to the fore at Farnborough



Photograph: London News Pictures

Geopolitical risks are [fuelling the aerospace and defence sector](#). So expect the balance between commercial and defence to skew in favour of military exhibitors at the biennial International Farnborough Air Show, which opens on Monday. It has “sold out twice over”, according to its organisers.

The sixth-generation GCAP fighter programme backed by Britain, Japan and Italy, which has secured funding for the next four years, will be a star of the show. Highly valued startups, such as Germany’s Helsing and America’s Anduril, will be vying to take on established defence contractors with their autonomous air and sea uncrewed vehicles. Several Ukrainian firms offering battle-proven, low-cost drone technologies and seeking Western investment will also draw attention.

As for the civilian side, there will be less interest in the traditional contest between Airbus and Boeing for commercial-aviation order announcements. With a combined order backlog of about 17,000 airliners, delivery rather than sales is the new yardstick of success.

Colombia's civil disobedience



Photograph: Getty Images

On Monday, the day Colombia each year celebrates independence from Spanish rule, left-leaning Colombians will march in defence of national sovereignty. Gustavo Petro, the outgoing president, is calling it a “second cry” for independence. Mr Petro refuses to recognise the victory of the [right-wing](#) populist Abelardo de la Espriella, who beat his rival, Iván Cepeda, in [last month's election](#) by less than one percentage point.

Mr Cepeda has called for “peaceful civil disobedience” ahead of the handover on August 7th. The left fears that the Trump-loving Mr de la Espriella will subordinate Colombia to United States’ interests, in particular by trading access to Colombia’s national resources for America’s help in fighting drug-trafficking gangs. They are worried by his threats to extradite Mr Petro to America. Their suspicions of the country’s new leader were heightened when a Colombian delegation to Washington last week was silent on the killing of a Colombian man by ICE agents in Maine two days earlier. Expect outrage in the streets of Bogotá.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Monday: Head & Shoulders is the best-selling brand of which type of household product?

*Sameness is the mother of disgust,
variety the cure.*

Petrarch